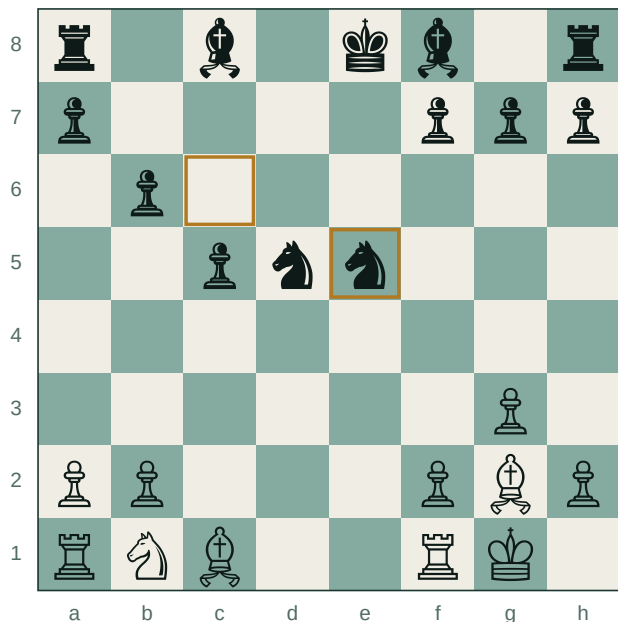


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 13

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 12...Nxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

13. Bxd5 Rb8 14. Re1 f6 15. f4

13.Bxd5 The bishop captures the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **13...Rb8**.

14.Re1 The rook moves from f1 to e1. Recorded reply: **14...f6**.

15.f4 The pawn moves from f2 to f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -4 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.